

Vibecamp

Rural Maryland holds a special place in my heart, as kids, my cousins, brother, and I would spend a summer weekend at Assateague, becoming incredibly sunburnt as we paddleboarded through waves which like mountains and valleys to children. For awhile, the other end of the state was my last stop before reuniting with a long-distance partner. Today, as vibecamp (VC)

Histories on the origin of VC exist elsewhere; the current iteration consists of a weekend organized by a core group of people, with programming by fellow attendees new & old. There is no single commonality tying campers together, but generally many have:

- used similar parts of twitter
- interested in tech or "woo"
- know what (modern) rationalism is

There is also an interesting demographic breakdown here (insert link). Personally, I've been on twitter for quite a bit, know about tech developments (but tend not to use them), and have a mild interest in woo and rationalism. Though I've known about it since it started, @rebqcd convinced me to go to this one (it helped that I'd recently realized that I hadn't taken a true vacation since I started working full time).

Describing VC linearly feels incorrect. The view truest to the experience ought to be that from one-thousand feet as campers bounce off each other like pinballs. Each event, while

important and fun, serves as a pretense for interacting & playing with others.

Play, defined broadly, is the shining aspect of VC. The future is an ongoing creation by our imagination, which is often dulled by daily monotony. The usual monotony is unavoidable — we all tend toward lower-energy patterns — but an event like this gives us license to break it, exercising atrophied muscles and introducing breaks. Some wish for a perpetual summer, this be taxing for the coordinators, the wish would end in a monotony of differences. Distinct contrasts are necessary.

VC provides a path for play, in action (unique events and shenanigans) and identity (any gathering with online roots has some degree of anonymity; with this, reinvention). If done correctly, these uncommon tools allow one to evaluate the way in which they live & find avenues to narrow the gap between their current & ideal selves, or find that their ideal self is not quite what they thought.

This is but one unique aspect, an opportunity to spend extended time among friends & strangers is also rare in an increasingly atomized and online world. Though it originates out of the internet, vibecamp is best experienced offline (I barely used my phone this weekend). In-person interaction is much more fulfilling, even if those people were originally met online. VC presents one of the better possible futures for living in this regard. One more familiar with this section of the internet may raise a point about cult formation; any sufficiently compelling concept should be able to form a cult! This proves its viability/longevity.

Part One: Belonging

Any gathering such as this one selects for those who tend to break traditional norms in some way. Generally, most norms exist because they are beneficial; vibecamp is exceptional for establishing a set of rules which allow those who differ to safely express themselves while protecting other attendees. This framework allows for a stronger sense of belonging.

As I understand it, belonging involves the full acceptance of one by a larger group. I have struggled with this throughout my life, I suspect many other VC'ers have. Let it be flaunting social norms, uncommon interests, or the difference in self-perceptions and reality, one begins to build a protective layer to survive, though this comes with the inability to belong, as they no longer bring their full self to the table. Such safety allows for one to fully inhabit their quirks. This is not an argument for doing so all the time — various aspects a person shine in different situations — but a full release is cathartic.

This is not to say I felt a continuous flow of this emotion. Friends appear and disappear into the forest, creating a feeling of missing out, or everyone hiding from you. This feeling is a childish one. Confronting this sense in the space allowed me to realize that there are people available everywhere you go. Additionally, that each has their own wants; misalignment is not a slight. Many realize this earlier. By the end of the weekend, this realization sits much closer to mind than before.

This does not dispute the value of shared experiences. Hot seat, singing together, arguing, etc. facilitate the feeling of belonging. One ought to create more of these moments in daily life.

As I write this I'm going through a socialization withdrawal; this happens whenever I spend large amounts of time with people. Then more than any other, gratitude is bubbling to the top.

Part Two: Serving Tea

The teahouse is central to VC; a place to relax, talk, cuddle, and re-energize oneself. Any good teahouse requires tea and a brewer, and that attendees may volunteer to take care of the space, sit at the table, serve tea, and make houseguests feel at home. Doing so may have been my most treasured experience this weekend. For being the barback for the brewer — it is pleasant to have a task to do for others which contributes to everyone's experience. And as for being the brewmistress, entertaining guests, getting them to talk to each other, and feel at home is a rare pleasure. I've always enjoyed hosting, but putting the self aside to become a means for others (voluntarily) is a unique experience. This was directly a topic of conversation in the objectification workshop I attended, but this provided a positive felt sense.

For future attendees should consider doing this; not only is it unique but it also allows you to meet those who you would not normally. One of the beauties of VC is the variety of people who pass through. Existing in the common spaces lets you meet them all and not stick to that you know alone. Similarly, put on events. This is another act of service to the larger weekend, sharing yourself with everyone and being accepted by those who you did not know until this point. Perhaps you can take something from this into your daily life.

Part Three: Assorted Takeaways

The past two sections are my longer thoughts on aspects of VC. There are also assorted thoughts from conversations or events which I would like to record for posterity. Here are a few:

- I should be ~20% more ok with nudity &

- Large groups are unhelpful and should be broken up to create better conversations
- Keeping contact with people is difficult for me but I desperately want to fix this
- Claude may be helpful for me
- The correct way to eat most cereal involves developing a highly personalized, neurotic method.
- Public song is beautiful & I ought to practice more
- There is such thing as too much salted licorice
- I should do my physical therapy exercises
- It is very easy to shit in public because no one expects you to be doing this (note: did not happen on Camp property)
- I should attempt to do stranger things
- Being objectified is fun (not that kind)
- Honesty is good but makes people uncomfortable
- Chocolate can be 50x better
- Shabbat is best shared
- Hammocks make wonderful sleep
- Our brains are very effective at changing self-perception
- I should be 20% louder
- Vegan meat alternatives are dangerously good
- There are lovely people everywhere
- I should be more woo

Part Four: Gratitude

This weekend was healing in a way which I've failed to express. To everyone who coordinated VC, put on events, and attended — you all succeeded in creating a good vibe. Nothing like this can be continuous; days like these are possible because of their

contrast with the others. However, in those more monotonous days, glimmers of light from these transcendent experiences help. If I were to list individual people, it would take too much in my journal. For those who I talked to, I'd love to do so again. Feel free to contact me anywhere. See y'all next year.

Signal: hjelfman.09

Email: hazel@hjelfman.com

X: @haleyon-hazel